

AWS Tunnel — User Guide

Manage AWS SSO profiles, connect to bastion hosts, and open secure tunnels — all in one place.

Welcome

AWS Tunnel is a cross-platform desktop app (Windows, macOS, Linux) that fills a gap the AWS console doesn't: it lets you manage your *IAM Identity Center (SSO)* profiles, log in, discover *bastion / jump hosts*, and open, monitor, and close *port-forwarding tunnels* to private resources — all from a single window, fully logged.

What you can do

- Create and manage AWS SSO profiles without hand-editing `~/.aws/config`
- Log in and out with one click (uses the AWS CLI behind the scenes)
- Auto-discover bastion hosts tagged in your AWS account
- Open SSM port-forwarding tunnels to databases and internal services — no SSH keys, no open port 22
- Save reusable *tunnel profiles* and reopen them with one click
- Start interactive terminal sessions on bastions via SSM
- Keep the app in the system tray so tunnels stay alive while you work

How to use this guide: use the table of contents on the left to jump to any topic. Screenshots reflect the app with sample data.

Getting Started

Prerequisites

Requirement	Why
Python 3.10+ (or the packaged executable)	Runs the app
AWS CLI v2 on your <code>PATH</code>	Handles <code>aws sso login</code> and its secure token cache
Session Manager plugin	Required by AWS for <code>aws ssm start-session</code> (tunnels & terminal). Install it from the AWS documentation for your OS.
IAM / SSO permissions	<code>sso:*</code> (login), <code>ec2:DescribeInstances</code> , <code>ssm:StartSession</code> , <code>ssm:DescribeInstanceInformation</code> , and the Session Manager messaging actions used by port forwarding.

SSM port-forwarding permissions: the role assigned through SSO must allow `ssm:StartSession` on both the bastion instance *and* the AWS-managed document `AWS-StartPortForwardingSessionToRemoteHost`. Your AWS administrator attaches this policy — the app cannot grant it.

Run from source

This project uses [uv](#) for dependency management, so there is no virtualenv to activate and no `requirements.txt` — dependencies and dependency groups live in `pyproject.toml`.

```
uv sync                # install dependencies
uv run python main.py  # add --debug to also log to the console
```

Run the packaged executable

If you received a packaged build (`aws-tunnel.exe` on Windows, a single executable on macOS/Linux), just start it — no Python needed. The AWS CLI and the Session Manager plugin must still be installed on the machine.

First-Run Setup Wizard

When you start the app and no SSO profiles exist yet, the **setup wizard** opens automatically and walks you through creating your first profile — mirroring `aws configure sso` in three friendly steps. You can also open it later via **New Profile** in the Profiles panel.

Step 1 — Configure the SSO session

- 1 Enter your organization's **SSO start URL** (usually `https://d-xxxxxxxxxx.awsapps.com/start`).
- 2 Pick the **SSO region** (the region your Identity Center is deployed in).
- 3 Click **Authenticate** →. Your default browser opens the AWS access portal — sign in there and approve the request.



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Step 1 of 3: enter the SSO start URL and region, then authenticate.

Step 2 — Select account & role

After authentication the app queries the SSO portal and lists every account and role you can assume. Pick the account, then the role (e.g. `AdministratorAccess`).



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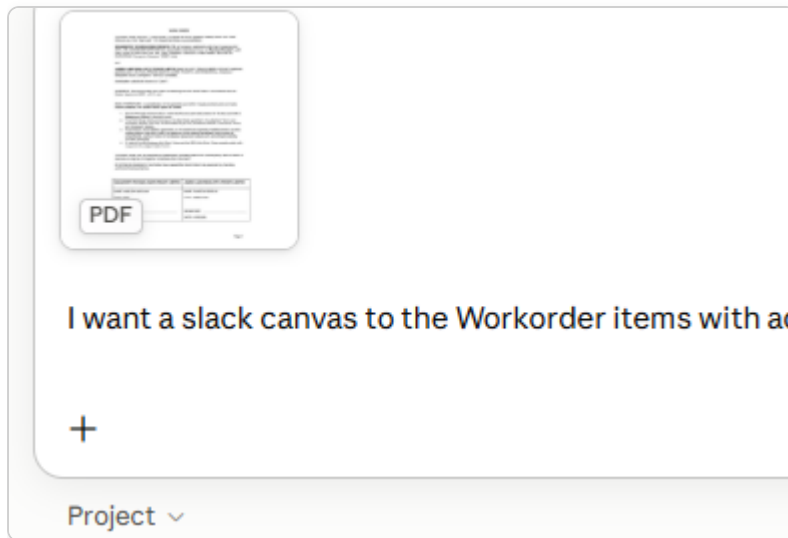
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Step 2 of 3: choose the account and role from your SSO portal.

Step 3 — Profile details

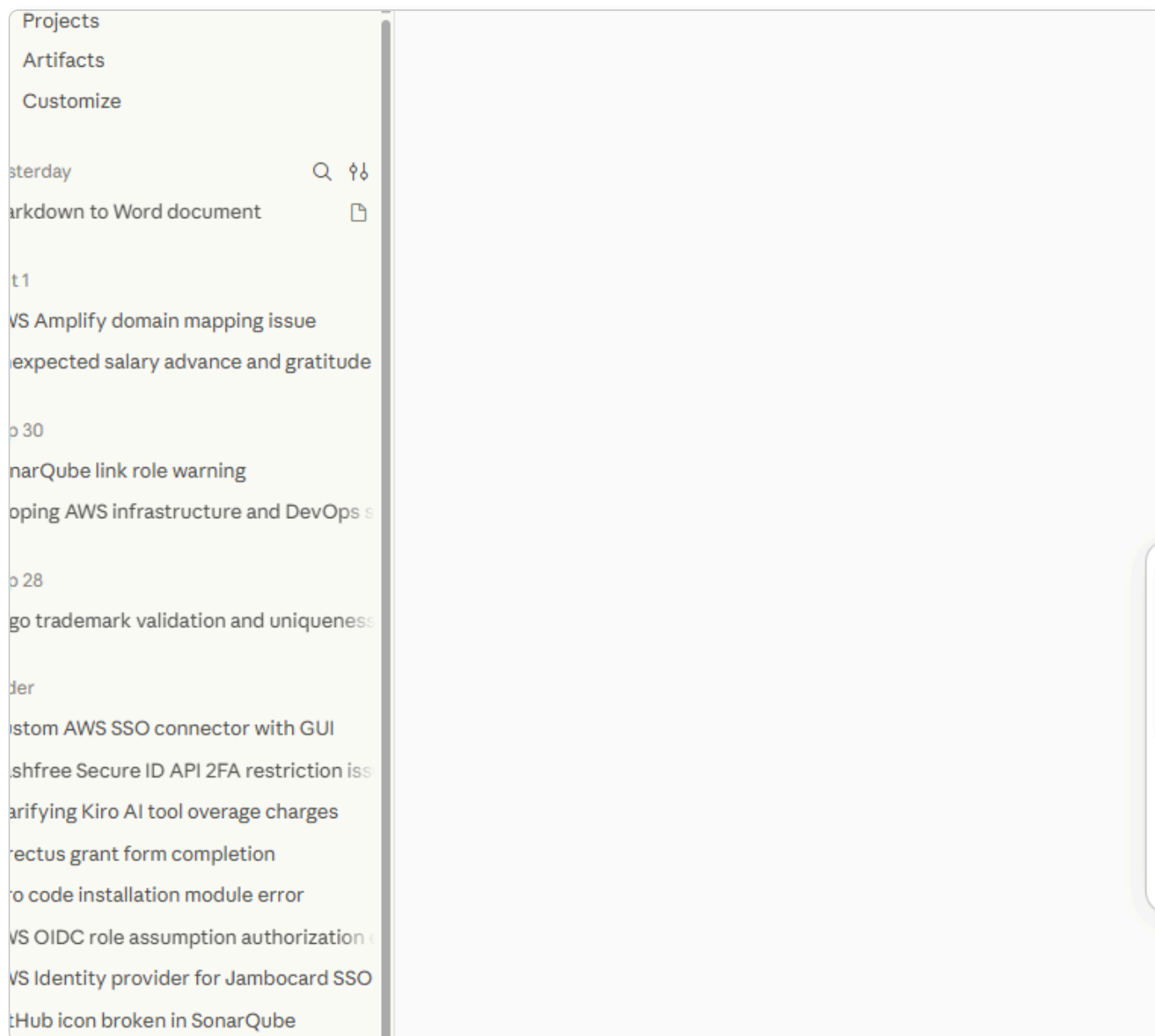
Give the profile a memorable name (e.g. `dev-admin`) and pick the **default region** for API calls. Click **Create** — the profile is written to `~/.aws/config` , exactly like the AWS CLI would, and the main window opens.



Step 3 of 3: name the profile and choose its default region.

AWS Profiles

The **AWS Profiles** panel at the top of the main window lists every SSO profile found in `~/.aws/config`, refreshed automatically (interval configurable in Preferences).



The main window: Profiles, Bastion Hosts, and Active Tunnels panels.

Column	Meaning
Profile	The profile name as stored in <code>~/.aws/config</code>
Account	AWS account ID the role belongs to
Role	The SSO role assumed through this profile
Status	Connected (valid SSO token) or Disconnected (expired / not logged in)
Region	Default region used for API calls

Buttons

Button	Action
Refresh	Re-reads profiles and re-checks login status
New Profile	Opens the 3-step setup wizard (same as first run)
Delete Profile	Removes the selected profile from <code>~/.aws/config</code> (asks for confirmation)
Login / Logout	Starts or ends an SSO session for the selected profile. The button label switches automatically; <code>double-click</code> a row toggles it too.

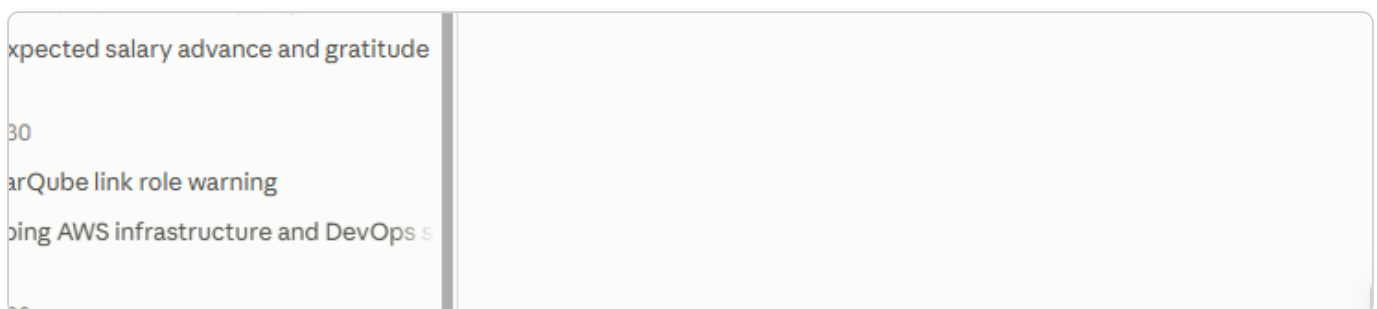
How login works: the app delegates to `aws sso login`, so tokens live in the AWS CLI's own cache (`~/.aws/sso/cache`). The app never stores or sees your credentials — it only checks whether a valid token exists for the profile.

Logging in opens your browser for the AWS access portal. When a profile is connected, the **Bastion Hosts** and **Active Tunnels** panels appear below and bastion discovery starts automatically for the selected profile.

Bastion Hosts

A *bastion* (jump host) is a small EC2 instance that has network access to private resources. The app discovers candidates automatically whenever you:

- log in to a profile,
- select a different profile, or
- press **Refresh** / right-click → **Refresh Bastions**.



Bastion Hosts panel — rows marked with the SSM Agent status.

How discovery works

- 1 Running EC2 instances tagged `Role=bastion` (configurable) are listed.
- 2 If *none* match the tag, all running instances are shown as candidates as a fallback.
- 3 Each instance is checked against SSM: **SSM Agent = Online** means it can be used for tunnels and terminal sessions right away.

Column	Meaning
Name	EC2 <code>Name</code> tag (or instance ID if untagged)
Instance ID	e.g. <code>i-0abc123def456</code>
Private IP	VPC-private address of the instance
State	EC2 instance state (<code>running</code> rows are usable)
SSM Agent	Online / Offline — required for SSM tunnels & terminal

Right-click menu

- **Connect Tunnel** — opens the saved tunnel profiles manager to open a tunnel through this bastion (see [Opening Tunnels](#))
- **Start Terminal** — interactive SSM shell on the instance (see [Terminal Sessions](#))
- **Refresh Bastions** — re-run discovery

Different tag convention in your environment? Change `bastion_tag_key` / `bastion_tag_value` in `~/.aws-tunnel/settings.json` — no code changes needed.

Opening Tunnels

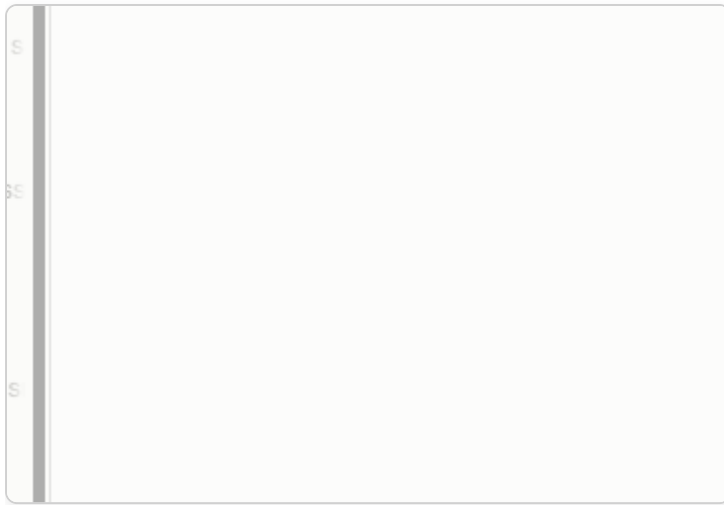
Tunnels use **AWS SSM Session Manager port forwarding** by default: your traffic goes through the bastion to a target host reachable *from* the bastion (a database, internal web app, ...) using your existing SSO credentials — no SSH keys and no open port 22.

The easy way — saved tunnel profiles

- 1 Log in to a profile and wait for bastions to appear.
- 2 Right-click a bastion → **Connect Tunnel**, or use **File** → **Tunnel Profiles...**
- 3 Select a saved tunnel profile and click **Open Tunnel**.
- 4 The tunnel appears in the **Active Tunnels** panel within a second or two, labelled with the profile name.

Creating a new tunnel profile

Open **File** → **Tunnel Profiles...** and click **New**:



The tunnel profile editor — save once, reopen with one click.

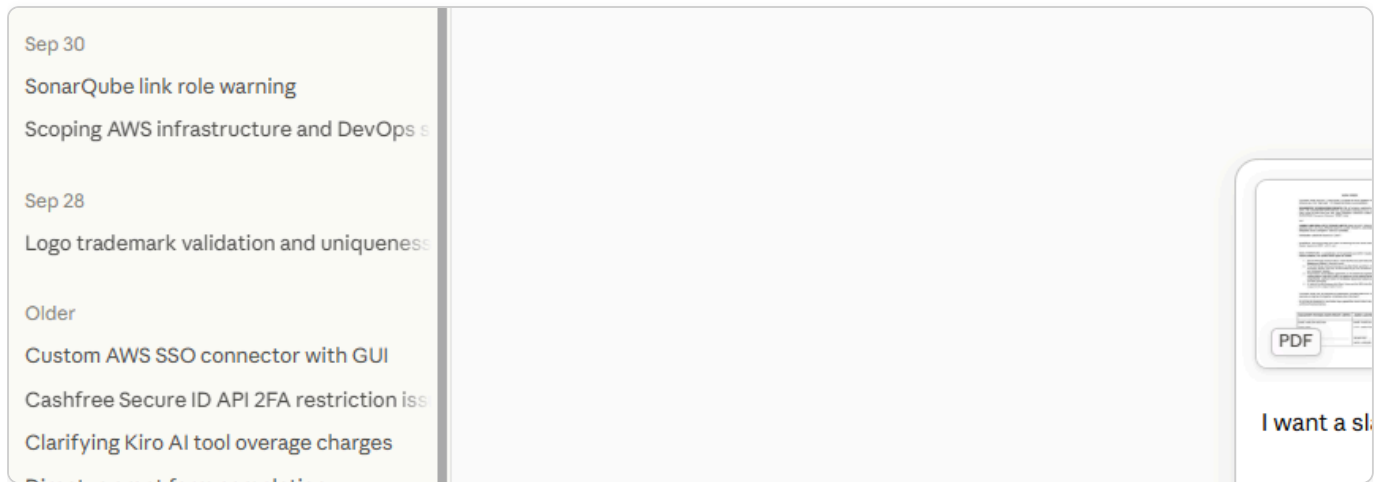
Field	What to enter
Name	A short label, e.g. <code>dev-postgres</code>
AWS profile	The SSO profile to authenticate with
Bastion instance ID	The jump host to tunnel through (dropdown of discovered bastions)
Target host	Hostname reachable <i>from the bastion</i> , e.g. an RDS endpoint
Target port	Remote service port (e.g. <code>5432</code> for PostgreSQL, <code>3306</code> for MySQL, <code>443</code> for HTTPS)
Local port	Free port on <i>your</i> machine, e.g. <code>15432</code> — you connect your client here
Description	Optional note

With the example above, pointing your database client at `localhost:15432` reaches `db.internal.local:5432` through the bastion. The profile is saved automatically so next time it's one right-click away. If a tunnel drops unexpectedly (e.g. network blip) the app **reconnects it automatically**.

Login happens automatically if the profile's token has expired — but if the SSO session itself needs a browser sign-in, complete it in the browser window that opens and the tunnel proceeds.

Saved Tunnel Profiles

File → **Tunnel Profiles...** opens the manager where every saved connection is listed and can be reused, edited, or removed.



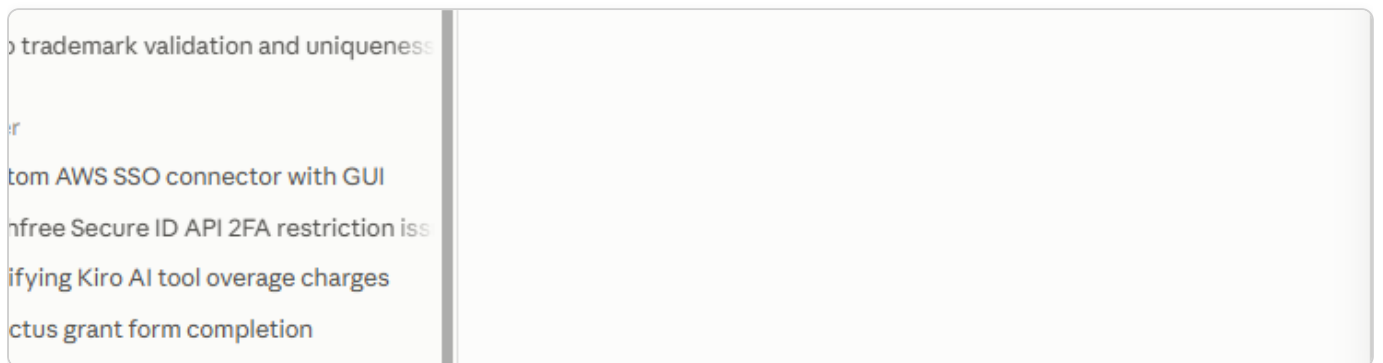
Tunnel Profiles manager — New / Edit / Open Tunnel / Delete.

- **New** — create a profile (see field table above)
- **Edit** — change any field of the selected profile
- **Open Tunnel** — connect immediately through the saved settings
- **Delete** — remove the profile (connection metadata only — never credentials)

Profiles are stored in `~/.aws-tunnel/settings.json` and survive app updates. Nothing sensitive is stored: only host names, ports, and profile names.

Monitoring & Stopping Tunnels

The **Active Tunnels** panel at the bottom of the main window shows everything currently open, with a live *uptime* clock.



Active Tunnels — select a row and press Disconnect to stop it.

Column	Meaning
Tunnel Profile	Name of the saved tunnel profile the tunnel was opened from; an em dash (—) means it was opened ad hoc
Target	<code>host:port</code> being reached on the remote side
Local Port	Your machine's endpoint for the tunnel (client connects here)
Method	<code>SSM</code> (port forwarding) or <code>SSM SESSION</code> (interactive terminal)
Bastion Host	Jump host the tunnel routes through
Uptime	Time since the tunnel started

Stopping a tunnel

- 1 Select the tunnel row.
- 2 Click **Disconnect**.

Tunnels also close cleanly when you quit the app from the tray or File menu — nothing is left running. If a tunnel dies on its own and it belongs to a saved tunnel profile, the app reconnects it automatically (unless it failed immediately due to a permission or configuration error — those are reported instead).

Terminal Sessions

Besides port forwarding you can open an **interactive shell** on any bastion whose SSM Agent is online:

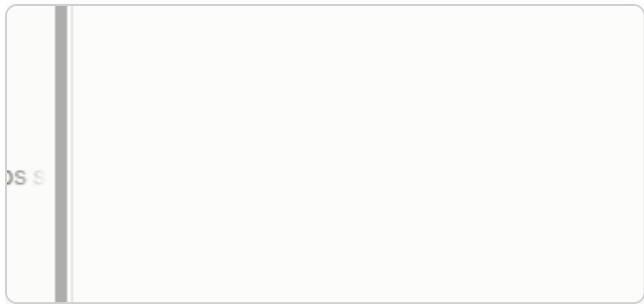
- 1 Select the profile and the bastion row.
- 2 Right-click → **Start Terminal**.
- 3 A Session Manager console window opens on the instance.

The session is tracked in the Active Tunnels panel (method `SSM SESSION`) and can be stopped like any tunnel. This requires no SSH keys either — it uses the same SSM channel.

If the SSM Agent shows **Offline**, Start Terminal and tunnel connections to that instance will fail. Verify the agent is running on the instance (or ask your AWS administrator).

Preferences

Open **File** → **Preferences...** to tune two behaviors:



Preferences — profile refresh interval and minimize-to-tray behavior.

Setting	Effect
Refresh profile status every(minutes):	How often the Profiles panel re-checks SSO tokens: 1, 5 (default), or 10 minutes.
Minimize to system tray instead of taskbar	ON (default): the minimize and close buttons both hide the window to the tray and tunnels keep running. OFF: closing the window quits the app, and minimize behaves normally.

Your window position is remembered automatically and restored on the next launch.

System Tray

The app places an icon in the system tray (menu bar on macOS):

- **Show** — bring the window back (default action when the icon is clicked)
- **Quit** — exit the app; all open tunnels are closed cleanly first

With *minimize to tray* enabled (default), both the **minimize** and **close** buttons hide the window to the tray instead of leaving it in the taskbar — your tunnels and token refresh keep working in the background. Use the tray menu's **Show** to bring the window back. The Linux/Unix tray uses the GTK/AppIndicator or Xorg backend; a desktop environment with a system tray is required.

Data, Logs & Security

Location	Contents
<code>~/.aws-tunnel/settings.json</code>	App settings and saved tunnel profiles (connection metadata only). If the file is ever corrupt, it is backed up to <code>settings.json.bak</code> and defaults are used.
<code>~/.aws-tunnel/logs/</code>	Rolling log files — every action (login, discovery, tunnel start/stop) is recorded. Reach this folder quickly via Help → Open Logs Folder .
<code>~/.aws/config</code>	Your AWS profiles — written only when you create/delete profiles, exactly like the AWS CLI does.
<code>~/.aws/sso/cache</code>	SSO tokens — owned entirely by the AWS CLI. The app only <i>reads</i> expiry times to show Connected/Disconnected status.

Security principle: the app never stores, transmits, or displays credentials or tokens. Tunnel profiles contain hostnames and ports only.

Troubleshooting

Where are the logs?

Help → **Open Logs Folder** (or `~/.aws-tunnel/logs/`). Run `python main.py --debug` for console output as well.

Common issues

Symptom	Likely cause & fix
Login fails or profile shows Disconnected	The SSO token expired. Click Login and approve the browser prompt. Check that the start URL and SSO region from the wizard are correct.
"Discovery failed" when listing bastions	The role lacks <code>ec2:DescribeInstances</code> / <code>ssm:DescribeInstanceInformation</code> , or you're offline. Check the log for the exact AWS error.
Tunnel fails to start with an access error	The role must allow <code>ssm:StartSession</code> on the bastion <i>and</i> on the document <code>AWS-StartPortForwardingSessionToRemoteHost</code> . Ask your AWS administrator to attach the scoped policy.
"SSM Agent is not reporting online"	The bastion's SSM agent isn't running or can't reach the SSM service. Start it on the instance or pick another bastion.
Session Manager plugin errors	The session-manager-plugin isn't installed. Install it from AWS's documentation for your OS, then retry.
Tunnel died mid-work	If the underlying session expired, the app reconnects automatically. Permanent errors (permissions, unknown host) are surfaced as a dialog instead — fix the cause and reconnect manually.
Settings seem reset	The settings file was unreadable; check <code>settings.json.bak</code> next to it for the previous contents.
No tray icon on Linux	A desktop environment with a tray/AppIndicator is required. On Debian/Ubuntu install <code>python3-tk</code> and AppIndicator/GI libraries (e.g. <code>gir1.2-ayatanaappindicator3-0.1</code>).

FAQ

Is my traffic or my credentials visible to this app?

No. Tunnels are plain `aws ssm start-session` processes driven by the AWS CLI — encryption and authentication are handled by AWS. The app stores no secrets; it only reads token expiry times to show status.

Why SSM instead of SSH?

SSM port forwarding needs no SSH keys, no inbound port 22, and uses your existing SSO identity — it is auditable through AWS Session Manager. A classic SSH tunnel module exists in the codebase as a fallback, but it is not wired into the GUI yet.

Can I use the same tunnel from several tools at once?

Yes — any number of clients can connect to the same local port while the tunnel is open. Open additional tunnels on different local ports in parallel.

What platforms are supported?

Windows, macOS, and Linux desktops. Binaries are built per platform with PyInstaller (the build must run on the target OS). The AWS CLI and Session Manager plugin install separately per OS.

How do I move my setup to another machine?

Copy `~/.aws-tunnel/settings.json` (tunnel profiles and preferences). Your AWS profiles and SSO tokens live with the AWS CLI in `~/.aws/` and are re-established by logging in on the new machine.